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KASTURBA NAGAR RESIDENT MAKES ALUMNAE MEET GREEN

The silver jubilee reunion of the 2001 batch of Women's Christian College offered an object lesson in sustainability **P2**



JUDGE A PURCHASE BY ITS COVER

From sharing unused bags to refusing unnecessary covers, these businesses in Chennai are finding ways to make packaging lighter, smarter and more responsible **P6**

A relief for Kotturpuram residents

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

Residents of Kotturpuram are heaving a thunderous sigh of relief watching a median opening at Gandhi Mandapam Road "behave" way differently than it had been for the past few months. To their delight, it has developed an attitude of magnanimity, no longer grudging residents on wheels the right to pass through it.

This opening in front of Velayan Street had been kept only

partially open, half of it being closed with metal barricades. Motorists had to squeeze their way through that small opening.

And the fact that the traffic signals at this partially-open opening had been allowed to take an indefinite break from work was not helping matters. There was just an orange light on the blink to indicate the presence of the opening.

Mohan Menon, a resident of Ranjit Road, notes that for a few days now, the opening is fully

open and the traffic signals have been made operational again, providing residents with smoother passage from one side of Gandhi Madapam Road to the other.

Kotturpuram residents hope this arrangement stays.

In its previous edition, The Hindu Downtown had highlighted the ineffectiveness of partially open median openings at Gandhi Mandapam Road. A resident had weighed in with her observations about the inconvenience this was causing residents.



Representational picture.

'Gated community on OMR serves as a torch bearer of solar wisdom'

Euphoria Apartments in Sholinganallur has saved considerably by investing in this green power

HARSHA KODA

Euphoria Apartments in Sholinganallur systematically evaluated technologies to install a phenomenal 144 kWp capacity solar installation - 50 kWp for common facilities and smaller systems for about half the apartments under the PM Surya Ghar Scheme.

This has also translated into savings of about ₹5 lakh for the association and 13,000 units (value of nearly ₹1.6 lakh) of electricity contributed back to the EB grid.

This move by the gated community followed a seminar conducted a year ago: Federation of OMR Residents Associations (FOMRRA) had organised a solar seminar that served as a major catalyst across the OMR corridor.

It sparked an incredible wave

of change, inspiring numerous Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs) along Old Mahabalipuram Road to actively explore renewable energy, with many already successfully adopting solar power for their common areas.

Any community on OMR that would want to dip into this knowledge pool about going solar may WhatsApp to 9042366772

(Harsha Koda is FOMRRA co-founder)

'Road surface at Guindy bridge has developed bumps'

H. MOSES DONALD

Through this report, I wish to draw the attention of the authorities to the hazardous condition of the road surface on the Guindy bridge in Chennai.

The surface on the bridge has developed several uneven bumps and undulations, making it extremely dangerous for two-wheeler riders. Navigating these irregular surfaces is particularly difficult for senior citizens and others who travel on motorcycles and scooters.

Riders are forced to slow down suddenly or swerve to avoid the

bumps, increasing the risk of accidents, especially during peak traffic hours and in wet weather.

As the bridge carries heavy traffic every day, it is essential that the road surface be inspected and restored to a smooth and safe condition without delay.

Timely maintenance would help prevent accidents and improve commuting safety for thousands of road users.

Are these bumps caused by poor workmanship, heavy traffic loads, settlement of the bridge deck, ongoing maintenance practices?

H.Moses Donald is a resident of Pazhavanthangal



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Kasturba Nagar resident makes alumnae meet green

The silver jubilee reunion of the 2001 batch of Women's Christian College offered an object lesson in sustainability, one that shut the door firmly on single-use plastics, use-and-throw culture and excess in celebration and opened the gates to composting of food waste, responsible consumption and green gifts

KANNAL ACHUTHAN

After the film 96, there is a pervasive trend of organising the silver jubilee reunion on a grand and memorable scale. 'Memorable' usually translates to adding extra layers to the celebration, sometimes making it extended to include a stop at a scenic location beyond the campus, say, a dinner at a resort. Rarely does 'memorable' mean paring the celebration to its bare minimum and make it meaningful, not just to the alumni but the wider world. When they met for their 25th on their campus in Nungambakkam on July 10, the 2001 batch of Women's Christian College embraced the rarer version of "memorable", having the event guided largely by two factors, simplicity and ecological sustainability.



ty. Saranya Palanichami (Kasturba Nagar resident and an ardent volunteer of Residents of Kasturba Nagar Association which works in the areas of waste management and sustainability) being part of this batch, one expected plastics to be shown the door. But the scale of the zero-waste consciousness she ushered in was beyond what was

imagined. "We did not have plastic water bottles or cups. Instead, we used steel tumblers for water and juice. No single-use cutlery. No printed invitations," notes Saranya.

Food waste was taken for composting. The alumnae got cloth bags made from fabric scrap from tailors and boutiques. These bits of cloth would have ended up in



▼ The batch; plants given to teachers and the 'enthu pataani' souvenir for alumnae; Saranya Palanichami; and cloth bag made with fabric bits. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND KANNAL ACHUTHAN



dumping grounds if not repurposed, she points out. Teachers, some of them now retired, received plants as mementos and winners of a fun quiz received gift vouchers.

Spotlight on SDG 3

It was a "celebration" of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) all the way. SDG 3, which is about health, was in bold relief, thanks to a panel discussion on navigating perimenopause. It made great sense as the alumnae are in their mid-forties. Ardhra Ashokan, who travelled from the United States for the reunion, said that it was important for women to be able to reach out among their own network for

support when going through this phase of life. "We need each other," she says, adding that the experts on the panel were drawn from the alumnae of WCC. Fitness and lifestyle coach Sheba Devaraj, clinical psychologist Debora Myrtle Anish of Stanley Medical College and Hospital and nutritionist-dietician Grace Gnana Priya discussed the importance of taking care of mind, body and soul. Sheba even did an onstage demo of the "inchworm workout", which requires no equipment and deploys one's own bodyweight for strength training. Gravitas and light-heartedness went hand in hand. After Susan George and group offered wonderful choral singing, the "madcap moments" started rolling. Going retro, the dancers of the batch performed to 'Mambo No. 5', the chemists in the batch donned lab coats to take a group photo and teachers sportively stepped in for a jive. Jubilee Daniel and Sobana Laxmi took people down memory lane with their quiz. And when they asked what was the name of the mangy dog that lived on campus in 1999, pat came the answer. Nobody had forgotten Henry, one of the few males on campus.

School in Sholinganallur celebrates Book Week



Babji Vidhyashram in Sholinganallur celebrated Book Week 2026 under the inspiring theme "Literary Leadership - The Power of Words," reinforcing the importance of reading in shaping thoughtful and compassionate leaders.

According to a press release, the week featured a vibrant Book Character Cosplay, Story Enactments on stage, TED talks, lunchtime book quizzes, a Classroom

Library Competition that showcased students' creativity and love for books, and an engaging Author Talk by celebrated author Timeri N. Murari, who inspired students with insights into the transformative power of literature and storytelling.

The celebrations reflected the school's commitment to fostering a strong reading culture and nurturing confident, articulate young minds, the press release adds.

Pedestrian safety should be ensured in Shastri Nagar



A transformer on a section of the footpath on First Main Road in Shastri Nagar, Adyar; and barricades on Mahatma Gandhi Road in Shastri Nagar. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T. D. BABU

In Shastri Nagar, there are four schools: two full-fledged schools, from primary to higher secondary, one Greater Chennai Corporation primary school, and a Balwadi.

Students have to access the schools through Mahatma Gandhi Road, First Avenue, First Main Road, Eleventh Cross Street, First Cross Street, and Tenth Cross Street.

Till there was no diversion, the parents and students were able to

access the schools without any fear.

The traffic diversion jointly implemented by the Greater Chennai Corporation, the Greater Chennai Traffic Police, Chennai Metro Rail Limited staff, and their contractors has posed serious safety hazards to the public.

Around two years ago, the diversion of traffic via First Main Road was carried out without taking any safety precautions and without consulting local residents about the diversions, which cost a life and left a person immobile. Many minor

accidents have occurred and continue to occur.

Even after the accidents, the government agencies and the project contractors have passed the buck till date, failing to ensure the safety of pedestrians in particular and the residents in general.

Adding to this chaos, diverting traffic through a much narrower road, 11th Cross Street, parallel to First Main Road, has raised doubts among residents and the general public about whether the government agencies have any concern for public safety.



11th Cross Street has hardly any pavements to walk on, and there is a four-way road junction, which has turned into a hotspot for accidents, and there is an S-bend at the end of 11th Cross Street to reach Mahatma Gandhi Road via Eighth Cross Street and 10th Cross Street, which are narrower than 11th Cross Street.

The Adyar Traffic Police says this arrangement is for six months and that allowing heavy vehicles into a residential area via narrow roads is unacceptable.

Heavy vehicles from Thiru Vi Ka Bridge towards Thiruvanniyur can be diverted via Besant Avenue, Besant Nagar Second Avenue, Seventh Avenue, and Mahatma Gandhi Road to Lattice Bridge Road without any further delay.

The First Main Road, Eighth, Tenth, and Eleventh Cross Streets should have zebra crossings for people to cross, speed breakers placed at strategic locations, and signage boards indicating school zones and no-horn zones; this will at least reduce safety risks.

Continuous, encroachment-free, and pedestrian-safe pavements have to be ensured.

Sufficient police personnel should be deployed on Eleventh Cross Street and First Main Road to regulate traffic and penalise motorists who violate one-way traffic

rules.

Further, since Mahatma Gandhi Road and First Avenue have been made two-way, Mahatma Gandhi Road has been continuously barricaded from First Main Road to the Lattice Bridge Road junction, leaving no space for local residents and the public to cross the road, access commercial establishments, or board buses at the halts.

Even the students at the neighbourhood schools are forced to risk their lives, crawling through the barricades to cross the road amid heavy traffic; the safety of pedestrians is completely ignored for unknown reasons.

Surprisingly, the traffic diverted through Indira Nagar prohibits heavy vehicles from entering the residential area, where human activity is much lower than on Tenth, and Eleventh Cross Streets, and First Main Road.

For the last two years, we, the residents of Shastri Nagar, have given petitions to the Greater Chennai Traffic Police, Greater Chennai Corporation Commissioner and the Chennai Metro Rail Limited to free the pavements on First Main Road to ensure the pedestrians' safety besides drawing zebra crossing lines and speed breakers, but no action has been taken.

T. D. Babu is the founder of Spark Social Welfare Association - Adyar

KAMARAJAR SALAI RESIDENTS

Kamarajar Salai, located on the Kottivakkam-Palavakkam border (Ward 183), is in a deplorable condition. We have so far raised ten formal complaints regarding this issue, yet no meaningful resolution has been provided.

For the past eight months, residents have been forced to endure an unsafe and deteriorating road due to prolonged infrastructure works. The road was initially excavated for sewage pipeline works, and is now dug up again for underground stormwater drain construction. Despite this extended period of disruption, the work remains incomplete.

The present condition of the road is unacceptable: Open and overflowing SWDs pose serious safety and public health risks; the

'With prolonged infrastructure work, Kamarajar Salai goes from bad to worse



File photo

road surface has been completely dug up and is filled with deep potholes, making it hazardous for motorists, cyclists and pedes-

trians; even temporary wet-mix levelling has not been carried out, despite repeated complaints; dust pollution has become unbearable due to the exposed road surface.

The area has no footpaths, forcing pedestrians—including senior citizens and school children—to walk on a busy carriageway.

There are no avenue trees, resulting in excessive heat, dust and a poor streetscape.

Kamarajar Salai is an important thoroughfare with significant daily traffic. Safe pedestrian infrastructure is not a luxury but a basic civic necessity. Residents should not have to risk accidents simply because there is no usable

footpath or properly maintained road.

With the monsoon approaching, we are deeply concerned that the situation will become even more dangerous. We experienced severe hardship during last year's November and December rains, when the damaged road became nearly impassable.

Equally concerning is that residents have repeatedly been directed between the Greater Chennai Corporation and the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board, with each department attributing responsibility to the other.

A joint site inspection by the

Greater Chennai Corporation and Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board must be taken. Complete the ongoing SWD works within a defined timeline.

Immediately level the road with wet mix or other suitable temporary measures to make it safe and motorable until permanent restoration is completed. Lay a proper asphalt road immediately upon completion of the underground works.

Construct continuous pedestrian footpaths on both sides of the road.

Plant avenue trees along the stretch to improve the environment, reduce dust and heat, and enhance the quality of the neighbourhood.

(This report was given by Residents of Kamarajar Salai in Kottivakkam-Palavakkam)

Charging needs sharing



While an EV charging point for each parking lot at a gated community is a desirable ideal, practicality calls for shared infrastructure

LIFFY THOMAS

Data engineer Kiruba Joy's search for a reliable EV charging facility in a gated community remains elusive. Three years ago, when the resident association at the 300-unit apartment community in Porur, where Kiruba owns a flat, refused to facilitate a separate connection for him to charge his electric car, he shifted to a rented accommodation in Kolathur.

Now a resident of Paniyur near Uthandi, for the last nine months Kiruba has been visiting various apartment communities in South Chennai to invest in a flat that comes with a separate charging infrastructure for every parking lot. The hunt has been frustrating.

"After the State Government brought a notification in October 2025 that buildings with more than 50 dwelling units should provide fast charging points, I took it up with my association but they refused citing a safety issue," says Kiruba.

At his current home, he has a 20 meter wire running from the second floor of his flat's AC point to the parking area. As there are only six homes and no other tenant with an EV vehicle, Kiruba got consent from the other residents.

A gazette notification dated October 31, 2025 by the Housing and Urban Development Department of Tamil Nadu issued amendments to the Tamil Nadu Combined Development and Building Rules, 2019. It asks residential communities to provide a charging point for electric vehicles at every car and two-wheeler parking space. In buildings where the number of dwelling units exceeds 50, car and two-wheeler parking space earmarked for visitors shall be provided with fast charging points.

Many apartment associations *The Hindu Downtown* spoke note they are physical and technical challenges in getting even a basic common charging infrastructure, let alone a separate charging point for every parking lot. While many apartment associations discourage individuals from connecting their vehicles to their own meter, some allow it at the individual's risk.

Christopher M.P., a resident of a 120-

unit apartment in Thiru-Vi-Ka Nagar, Perambur, has a wire running from the third floor of his flat to the parking area where his electric two-wheeler is parked.

"Currently we have 6 electric vehicles in our community and the association was considering putting up a common charging point, but the vendor came up with the condition that even outsiders should be allowed to use the facility, which was not accepted, so we continue with this arrangement," says Christopher.

Many users like Kiruba who have switched to EV to reduce the budget on their fuel bills feel having just one or two charging points does not serve the purpose.

"For instance, it takes eight hours to charge my car and if there are even half-a-dozen EV cars in the community so you need an ample number of charging points," says Kiruba. He adds, "Charging from my home is cheaper than doing so at a common point as the latter involves a commercial rate and a fee for the vendor and association. So I am now looking for a community that also offers solar so my electricity bill would reduce drastically."

CREDAI's stand

After the State Government notification, the Confederation of Real Estate Developers' Association of India - Chennai sent a letter to the Additional Chief Secretary, Housing and Urban Development Department in November 2025, stating that it is not possible to provide individual charging infrastructure even in their upcoming projects.

"The requirement of a one-to-one charger-to-parking ratio may be technically unnecessary, financially burdensome, and operationally impractical, especially in large residential developments," reads the letter signed by A. Mohamed Ali, president, CREDAI- Chennai.

The Confederation suggested that Tamil Nadu follow a progressive, scalable model that includes a minimum of three EV chargers for buildings with 10-75 parking slots; one charger per 25 parking slots thereafter; upgradation to one per 18 slots by 2030 and one per 15 slots by 2035; and mandatory trunking, ducting and electrical provisioning to double capacity when required.

99 and counting

Enduring gems

Even as Music Academy is on course to complete its hundredth year, three other enterprises, also born on Madras soil in 1927, are headed in the same direction. A salute to auction house Murray & Co, pen seller Gem & Co and timeless rose milk sensation Kalathi Shop for their endurance and uniqueness

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

There are four parts to longevity in business. One part is ingenuity, and the other three are just plain, old-fashioned, boring stick-to-itiveness. Those four parts working in perfect synchronicity, seller of pens, a whopping number of them fountain pens, Gem & Co has continued at the same address on NSC Bose Road in George Town for no less than 99 years. As it is poised to complete 100 years of existence in February 2027, there are no signs it could be running out of ink.

M. Pratap Kumar, representing the third-generation at the reins of Gem & Co after grandfather M.C. Cunnann and father M. Prabhat Kumar, has had greater need for those three parts because of the times in which he is holding those reins. Pratap is penning Gem & Co's brand story challenging the digital onslaught as seen by the writing pad being increasingly replaced by the keyboard.

And then there are the mundane hiccups, the gremlins that play a nasty trick on you when you do not even suspect their existence. Having seen 64 summers, Pratap has had a share of these niggles, finding some of those summers tough, and some winters too, the latter indicated by the shop's increased height.

"We had to increase the height of the shop because of the water coming in during every rain as a result of the road level going up over the decades, and we had to

pump out the water or manually push it out," explains Pratap.

The overarching challenge however comes from the digital takeover of writing and the pervasive disposable, throwaway culture particularly pronounced where stationery is concerned. In 1927, when his grandfather M.C. Cunnann and business partner S. Venkatarangam Chetty were seeking to shift the focus of their business from general trade to one focussed on an exclusive product line, and the lot fell on fountain pens and Gem & Co as its known today was born, no hazy clouds of doubt hung over the decision. The clouds would not drift in for many decades to follow. Back then selling fountain pens was a sensible choice as children often went through the grades with the same fountain pen.

"Now , this business is not feasible, but we are still running it because of the passion we have for fountain pens. It is running in my blood," Pratap observes, sheer pride in the trade overriding everyday realities. "The profit is less; customers have become less." Pratap has steered the family business since 1985 and the enthusiasm for designing and selling fountain pens, particularly hand-crafted artisanal pens has not flagged. True to what its name is associated with, the Gama line of fountain pens made and marketed by Gem & Co remains "undefeated". It is named after the legendary undefeated pehalwani wrestler Ghulam Hussain Baksh Bhat (1878-1960) who went by the ring name "The Great Gama".

"My grandfather was a patriot and a freedom fighter; he wanted the pen to be named after an Indian hero," Pratap observes. "My grandfather would have thought

the pen would be as strong as the wrestler."

Pratap reveals that "the making of plastic moulded pens are outsourced to manufacturers elsewhere in India such as Mumbai. The ebonite, hand-crafted pens are made by us." Though remaining steadfast to its ebonite craftsmanship, the company has embraced the changing times by introducing models, vibrant acrylic and transparent demonstrator fountain pens among them, likely to appeal to the younger generations. The store also repairs fountain pens, restoring what are treasured possessions to their keepers and cannot be valued in purely materialistic terms.

Who actually keeps Gem & Co up and writing its long story?

Certainly not those like this reporter who was briefly drawn to a fountain pen just to have an experience close to that of a Victorian writer hunched over an unwritten page, a dip pen in hand, a lit candle on the table, and perhaps, a dramatic rumble of thunder disturbing the quiet. The patrons of Gem & Co are not drawn to

fountain pens on account of a fleeting excitement; they have written the use of fountain pens into their everyday script.

"We are able to sustain the business because of the generation that has been buying from us for 40, 50 and 60 years. But the customer base is not restricted to them. A steadfast customer, who is 92

years old, continues to buy from us, now for his grandchildren. People from those generations pass on the interest to their children and grandchildren, who head to our shop to buy fountain pens.

A 'rose' keeps blooming

Kalathi Shop at North Mada Street in Mylapore shuns the glare of public attention. Text requests for newspaper interviews can go unanswered. Considerable ink about Kalathi shop has been spilt on newsprint; and the novelty of press coverage has long worn off. Food bloggers and vloggers have offered it their share of glorification; there are enough bytes about Kalathi out there to sustain a 24-hour nonstop programming schedule on television. On Google, Kalathi shop manages an impressive 4.3 against 4,193 Reviews.

So much attention being showered on a petty shop, its limited dimensions and address unchanged since its inception in 1927, for what? A drink it fills a small rectangular pet bottle with. Its rose milk has captured generations of taste buds. It sells other items including newspapers, but reels in visitors from far and wide for its rose milk, and has consolidated a set of loyal followers far beyond Mylapore's radius.

For the last 15 years since he discovered this shop, Suresh Kumar. V., a resident of Valasaravakkam, has headed to North Mada Street many a time just to savour the chilled drink.

Many try to recreate the taste at home buying rose milk essence from Kalathi. Siji S., a resident of Nungambakkam, says she has experimented with Kalathi's rose milk essence several times. While she has come close, she admits she has never been able to plicate the exact taste.

Pratap seeks to present a proper measure of fountain pens, one shorn of the romance that goes with them. They are "economical, eco-friendly and remarkably durable"; he however, believes their value lies beyond practicality.



Gem & Co at NSC Bose Road in George Town.

'Every transaction is special': Murray & co

Since February 10, 1927, the hammer at this auction house has not had a break except for two seasons. The operational space has changed a few times, but its place in people's mind space has not



The team at Murray & Co

becoming a household name. Murray & Co has done both. After being identified with one space for a long time, a space behind the iconic LIC building on Mount Road, it has had to change addresses,

but its hold on the mind space of the city's residents has been unchanging and firm.

Hemant throws light on the addresses the auction house has had to its name.

"Our original auction room was located behind the LIC Building until 2012. We then briefly operated from Mandaveli before moving to our current premises at Gemini Towers, near the Gemini Flyover."

On how the business has evolved over the years, he observes: "We started with real estate auctions. From there, we expanded into retail auctions of household goods and furniture, followed by industrial auctions. There has always been a transition as the business adapted to changing times."

Hemant continues: "Within the retail space, the categories have changed significantly. We sell far more electronic items today than when I joined the business in 1992. The market has evolved, and so have the items."

Online auctions are becoming increasingly popular. Where does Murray & Co stand in cyberspace?

"Our industrial auctions are already completely online. Our retail auctions have not fully transitioned yet, though our online portal is currently being developed. Even after it is launched, we want to continue our physical auctions because they have a charm of their own that no technology can replace," says Hemant. And when prodded to name one transaction that has been hugely memorable for Murray & Co in the almost 100 years of its existence, Hemant refuses to take that route.

"Every single item is memorable. Every transaction is special, not just for us, but for the person who entrusted it to us and, hopefully, for the person who eventually bought it." Have grands plans been etched to celebrate the centenary when it arrives? "Yes, the plans are still in the works. Over the next few months, we will come up with concrete ideas to celebrate the centenary."

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

A statement about mindful choices

Packaging doubles as a brand statement. A clothing label at Karpagam Gardens in Adyar, Tula India has dispensed with the branding part and instead made packaging a statement about mindful choices.

"We will ask customers to bring their own bags. Most of our customers do, and we'll also educate them," says Sushmitha R.K, designer at Tula India.

The approach begins well before a garment reaches the store. Cotton is transported in airtight plastic sacks that are reused year after year, while woven fabric moves between production units in reusable sack bags instead of new packaging. "So the cycle keeps repeating. Instead of buying new plastic covers every time and discarding them, we keep reusing what we already have," she says.

Garments are displayed without individual plastic covers. Customers are encouraged to bring their own bags, but those who forget are offered newspaper bags made by autistic adults using recycled newspapers or reusable cloth bags stitched from leftover organic cotton fabric. "Whatever big pieces of fabric are left after production, we make our cloth bags from them," says Sushmitha, adding that the bags are often pieced together from two or three fabric scraps.

The leftover fabric also serves another purpose. Larger parcels are wrapped in these fabric pieces, while smaller consignments are sent in paper envelopes.

Interestingly, the cloth bags are not sold despite customer demand. "Many people want to buy those bags because they like them. But we tell them the bag is not for sale. There's no purpose in buying another bag just to own it when you already have many bags at home," she says.

The store also uses conversations and posters to encourage customers to rethink disposable packaging.

For more information on Tula's approach to reducing unnecessary packaging, contact 8056163560 / www.tula.org.in

The bag bank

A cardboard box outside the entrance of Kazhani Native Farms in Kottivakkam has become an unlikely solution to a common retail problem. Instead of selling new carry bags, the farm invites customers to drop off extra shopping bags for others to reuse.

For Gokulnath Natesan, founder of Kazhani Native Farms, the idea stemmed from a growing dependence on packaging as the farm expanded its range of products. "As the product range increased, the

Aesthetically designed boxes, glossy wraps and branded bags often shape the way we purchase. But behind the appeal lies a growing question: how much packaging do we really need? From sharing unused bags to refusing unnecessary covers, these businesses in Chennai are finding ways to make packaging lighter, smarter and more responsible

Judge a purchase by its cover



Environment-friendly packaging and containers at Tula and Restore.

usage of packaging materials also increased," he says. "We realised that while we were conscious about sustainability and waste management, in another way we were increasing the usage of plastics."

Walk-in customers are encouraged to bring their own bags and containers, particularly for loose produce. For products such as juices and oils, customers are asked to return the same containers for refills. "We will fill it again and give it to you. Until it is good, you can use it instead of throwing it away," says Gokulnath.

The cardboard box outside the store extends the same idea. Customers leave behind extra carry

bags they no longer need, allowing others who arrive without one to reuse them.

"Instead of charging them, we told them they can take the bag. Similarly, if you have excess bags at home, you do not need to throw them away or keep filling your shelves. Just leave them here," he says. While home deliveries still rely on plastic packaging where alternatives prove impractical, Gokulnath says the reuse initiative has significantly reduced the farm's purchase of new carry bags.

"It has reduced our bag purchasing costs and plastics, and it has become a good habit for people," he says. "As others started dropping off excess covers, they also began

bringing other waste."

The farm now serves as a drop-off point for vegetable and garden waste, dry waste, e-waste and old garments. "The transaction does not end with the purchase," says Gokulnath. "It goes back as a message, creates awareness and builds an eco-friendly environment together."

For more information, contact @kazhani.in / Instagram - [@kazhanifarms](https://www.instagram.com/kazhanifarms)

Take a discount in your own bag

For most shoppers, the bag is an afterthought – a necessity con-

sidered only after the purchase is complete. At Restore on East Coast Road, Kottivakkam, it is the starting point of the shopping experience, where customers are encouraged to carry their own bags and rethink the way they approach packaging.

Restore functions as the sister concern of Organic Farmers Market (OFM), an initiative built around connecting farmers directly with consumers. While both operate independently, they share a network of farmers and a common vision of creating a more community-driven approach to consumption.

Customers who walk in with their own bags or containers receive a 2% discount on groceries, a small gesture that encourages a larger change in the way people approach packaging.

According to Karthik R, General Manager, the idea is to make carrying reusable bags a natural part of the shopping routine. "We request customers

to bring their own bags and containers, especially for planned purchases like rice, grains and pulses," he says.

According to Karthik, although the discount is small, customers have responded positively to the initiative. Since nearly 70% of the revenue already goes back to farmers, the organisation cannot offer a larger discount.

However, he says the incentive has helped encourage more customers to adopt the practice. This practice has been part of Restore's approach for years. Plastic packaging has almost completely been eliminated from the store, with brown paper bags provided only when required. For products such as oils, customers are encouraged to bring their own containers, while glass bottles are available for those who need an alternative. But getting people to change a familiar habit has taken time. "In supermarkets, everything is packed and ready. People simply grab products and leave," says Karthik. "Asking customers to bring their own bags is a completely different paradigm."

He says the challenge is not the availability of alternatives, but the mindset around them. "People think minimal packaging is difficult or doesn't suit their lifestyle. But it's actually very easy," he says. "Customers tell us bringing their own containers simply becomes another item on their shopping checklist." There are, of course, practical hurdles. Paper bags can sometimes tear under heavier loads, requiring the store to constantly adapt its packaging methods. Yet, the focus remains unchanged.

For more information, contact @restore.org.in / Instagram - [@restoreorg](https://www.instagram.com/restoreorg)



Second generation Bharatanatyam artistes honoured

Performances by intellectually challenged and visually impaired artistes were among the other highlights of the event at Rukmini Arangam



Kala RASA Parampara Vaibhava, presented by RASA Arpita, concluded at Rukmini Arangam, celebrating 55 years of artistic excellence and 40 years of Natyacharya excellence of Ambika Kameshwar. The event honoured second-generation Bharatanatyam artistes carrying forward their gurus' artistic legacies while

showcasing the transformative power of inclusive arts through moving performances by visually impaired and intellectually challenged artistes.

According to a release, the highlight of the celebration was the felicitation of distinguished second-generation Bharatanatyam artistes including Sukanya Ravindhar

Visweswaran's Chidambaram Academy of Performing Arts, Chennai), C. P. Satyajit (Bharata Kalanjali), and Aruna Rengasamy (Ramana Natyalaya). The honours celebrate artistes who uphold the Guru-Shishya Parampara and ensure its continuity.

Anbu, a moving presentation by the visually challenged artistes of Shri Ramana Maharishi Academy for



Performance by visually challenged artistes; and the second generation artistes who were felicitated

the Blind, Bengaluru, an outreach centre of RASA and the very first space where Ambika Kameshwar began her work with persons with special needs, and Margazhi Mahimai, a presentation by the RASA Stars, artistes with intellectual disabilities were the main performances.

The celebration was graced by Padma Subrahmanyam, renowned musician Rajkumar Bharathi, senior artistes, scholars, disciples and distinguished members of the arts fraternity.

Padma Subrahmanyam said, "Training any student is a challenge, but training

visually challenged students requires extraordinary patience, dedication, and compassion. Ambika Kameshwar has done a truly remarkable job. Their performance in Anbu reflected the utmost perfection and rigorous training imparted by the guru."

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During the event. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Handicraft expo at Egmore Museum campus

The Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Limited (Poompuhar) is having a handicraft exhibition till July 19 at Government Museum campus in Egmore.

Aimed to promote handicraft

heritage, the event provides a common platform for artisans from various states to market their products directly to the public, said a release.

From bronze icons to brass traditional lamps, Thanjavur paintings, art plates, papier mache dolls,

bamboo crafts, wood carvings, stone sculptures, clay and terracotta products, cane furniture, jute products, fashion jewellery, incense and perfumery, there's a lot to choose from.

Purchasing traditional handcrafted products from artisans will

support the livelihoods of artisans and craft communities while preserving India's rich artistic and cultural heritage, the release added.

The expo was inaugurated on July 7 by P. Mathan Raja, Minister for Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises.

T. N. Venkatesh, Principal Secretary, Government of Tamil Nadu, Handlooms, Handicrafts, Textiles, and Khadi Department, and S. Amirtha Joshi, Managing Director, Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Limited (Poompuhar), participated.

Changes in pattern of train services

The Chennai Division of the Southern Railway has enacted changes in the pattern of electric train services on July 12 to facilitate line and power blocks in Chennai Egmore - Villupuram section, between Chennai Beach and Tambaram railway station, from 10.30 a.m. to 15.30 p.m. for engineering works.

Full cancellation of electric trains

Train Numbers : 40329, Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 10:30 a.m., 40623, Chennai Beach - Chengalpattu at 10:45 a.m., 40331, Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 11 a. m., 40333, Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 11.15 a.m., and 40335, Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 11:30 a.m.

Passenger special trains

Chengalpattu - Tambaram at 9.30 a.m., Kancheepuram - Tambaram at 9.30 a.m., and Tambaram - Chengalpattu at 11.45 a.m., 12.45 and 13.15 p.m.. will be operated.

Cancellation of trains

On July 13 and 15, the following trains will be cancelled. Train Numbers: 40531, Chennai Beach - Chengalpattu, at 11. 28 a.m., 40533, at 12.02 p.m., 40535, at 12:30 p.m. and 40540, Chengalpattu - Chennai Beach at 13.35 p.m..

Passenger specials

Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 11.28 a.m., 12.02 p.m., 12.30 p.m.. and at 13.45 p.m.

For full details, log on to <https://x.com/DrmChennai>

Tamizh Theatre Festival from July 14

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan is conducting "Tamizh Theatre Festival 2026" consisting of four dramas from July 14 to July 17 at its main auditorium in Mylapore.

The inaugural event is scheduled for July 14 at 6 p.m. This year "Iyakkunar Sigaram K.Balachander Award-2026" (instituted by Kavithalayaa Sri Krishnan) to well-known drama artist Sachu will be presented on the inaugural day. The dramas will be staged every day at 6.45 p.m. On July 14: UAA presents Varadu Kutty-Paritchaikku Neramachu 2,; July15 Three presents Kaatriniley Varum Geetham; July 16, KNT presents Veera; July 17, TV Varadharajan and team presents Sangeetha Mumoorthigal. The programmes are open to all.

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